

Five Checks *That Lie*

Five passing checks that proved nothing, found in one person's own pipeline in 48 hours. Every one of them produced a real green signal. Each measured something adjacent to what was actually being cared about -- a passing test proves the code behaves the way the test invokes it, not that the program runs.

RUN THESE AGAINST YOUR OWN SUITE

In order. Each one takes minutes to check, and tells you honestly whether a green result means what you think it means.

01 The billed-API mirage

- LOOKS LIKE** A suite that passes because it is quietly making real, billed calls to a live API -- it only fails in CI, where there is no key.
- VERIFY** Run the suite with the API key unset. If it still passes, it was never testing your logic.
- REAL PASS** The suite runs against a mock or fixture, no key and no network required. A separate, clearly labeled integration test covers the live call.

02 The URL that resolves to nothing

- LOOKS LIKE** A trace URL returns success and resolves to nothing. The check confirmed a URL came back, not that it pointed anywhere real.
- VERIFY** Take the URL your check produced and actually open or fetch it.
- REAL PASS** The check asserts on the content the URL resolves to, not on the shape of the string.

03 The import path only the test runner sees

- LOOKS LIKE** Demo scripts break with a `ModuleNotFoundError` while the suite stays green -- the test runner put the repo root on the import path, running the script directly does not.
- VERIFY** Run every entry point the way a real user would, outside your test runner's environment.
- REAL PASS** The suite exercises the same import path your real entry points actually use.

04 The test that cannot fail

- LOOKS LIKE** Fixtures written in markdown for an OCR pipeline. Markdown is already machine-readable, so the test cannot fail -- which means it cannot pass either.
- VERIFY** Ask one plain question: what would actually make this test fail? If you cannot describe it, the test is not testing anything.
- REAL PASS** Fixtures use the real input format the pipeline was built for -- an actual scanned image, not a transcription of what it says.

05 The single-file grep close

- LOOKS LIKE** A task closed after grepping one file for the right constant, while a second render path still showed the old value.
- VERIFY** Search every path that could touch the value, then check what a user actually sees, end to end -- not just what the source file now says.
- REAL PASS** The value shows correctly wherever it is produced or rendered, not just wherever it happens to be stored.

"If a check has never failed, you have not verified that it works."

NEXT STEP

Found one of these in your own pipeline? **DM "READY" on LinkedIn** for a free AI readiness working session, no fixed price.

Want the same audit run against your team's actual test suite? **DM "AUDIT"** for the paid AI Workflow Audit.

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